

How to Run the Admissions Portal Application

This guide contains the instructions to set up, launch, and test the admissions portal application.

1. Prerequisites

Ensure you have the following installed on your system:

- **Node.js** (v18 or higher recommended)
- **PostgreSQL** database service (running locally)

2. Environment Configuration

Check the dotenv configuration file located at:

 Backend/mock-server/.env

Make sure the PostgreSQL credentials match your environment:

```
DATABASE_URL=postgresql://<database_user>:<database_password>@localhost:5432/vit_  
JWT_SECRET=<your_jwt_secret_key>  
COUNSELOR_USERNAME=<your_counselor_username>  
COUNSELOR_PASSWORD=<your_counselor_password>
```

Note: The mock backend server contains automatic schema migration. If the `vit_admissions` database does not exist, the server will create it automatically on startup as long as the connection to the base `postgres` administrative service succeeds.

3. Launching the Application

Option A: Automatic Launch (Windows PowerShell)

Run the script in the project root to start both servers in separate windows:

```
.\run-local.ps1
```

Option B: Manual Launch (Command Line)

If you prefer running them in separate terminals:

1. Start the Mock Backend Server:

```
cd Backend/mock-server  
npm install  
node server.js
```

Will be live at: <http://localhost:8080>

2. Start the Next.js Frontend Server:

```
cd Frontend  
npm install  
npm run dev
```

Will be live at: <http://localhost:3001>

4. Application Access URLs & Credentials

Once running, access the web pages using these links:

- **Student Application Portal (Anonymous Registration):**

 <http://localhost:3001/> or <http://localhost:3001/apply>

- **Counselor Admissions Portal (Protected Dashboard):**

 <http://localhost:3001/counselor/login>

- **Counselor Username:** The `COUNSELOR_USERNAME` value set in your `.env` (e.g. `counselor`)
- **Counselor Password:** The `COUNSELOR_PASSWORD` value set in your `.env` (e.g. `counselor@vit`)

5. Verification Test Suite

To verify backend routing, JWT tokens, PostgreSQL db insertions, and AI insights calculations, run the integration test script:

```
cd Backend/mock-server
node verify-dashboard-endpoints.js
```

All tests should display `SUCCESS` and finish with  `ALL LIVE ADMISSIONS ALIGNMENT TESTS PASSED!` .